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Committee, government-run media—has been misused. Congressmen will never be able to explain away this stigma on their leader.

The issue of her foreign origin resurfaced again in May 2004, after the elections to the 14th Lok Sabha, and is still far from settled.

■ ATAL BIHARI VAJPAYEE

Many people have asked me, “How did your partnership with Atalji endure for over fifty years? Did you never have any differences or problems with him?”

Contrary to what some people have never tired of speculating the relationship between Atalji and me was never competitive, much less conflictual. Yes, we had our differences. This is natural in any organisation that values internal democracy. However, what lent depth to our relationship were three factors. We both were strongly moored in the ideology, ideals and ethos of the Jana Sangh and the BJP, which commanded all its members to put the nation first, party next, and self last. We never allowed differences to undermine mutual trust and respect.

But there was also a third and a very important factor: I always implicitly and unquestionably accepted Atalji to be my senior and my leader. I would put forth my views but once I sensed what Atalji wanted, I would invariably go along with his viewpoint or preference. I used to tell my colleagues, “No family can stay together without a *mukhiya* (head), whose authority is accepted by all its members. After Deendayalji, Atalji is the *mukhiya* of our family.”

Here, I must also add that Atalji had an accommodative approach towards me. If he knew what my thinking was on a certain issue, and if he did not have serious disagreements over it, he would readily say, “*Jo Advaniji kehte hain, woh theek hai.*” (What Advani says is right.)

Let me cite two examples when significant differences arose between Atalji and me. He had some reservations about the BJP getting directly associated with the Ayodhya movement. But being a thorough democrat, Atalji accepted the collective decision of the party.

The second instance pertains to the time when communal violence broke out in Gujarat. The demand for Modi's resignation raised by the Opposition parties had reached a crescendo. Some people within the BJP and the ruling NDA coalition also began to think that Narendra Modi should be asked to quit. However, my view on this matter was totally different. He was more sinned than sinning.

I therefore felt that it would be unfair to make Modi, who had become the state's chief minister less than a year ago, a scapegoat for what was decidedly a complex communal situation. Doing so, I reckoned, could worsen the social fab-



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ric in Gujarat in the long term. I knew that Atalji was as profoundly pained as I was due to the happenings in Gujarat. He felt that something needed to be done. Meanwhile, pressure was mounting on him to ask Modi to resign. Although Atalji had not expressed his view explicitly on this matter, I knew that he favoured Modi's resignation. And he knew that I disfavoured it. Shortly thereafter, in the second week of April 2002, the BJP's national executive was to meet in Goa. Atalji asked me to accompany him on his journey from New Delhi to Goa. Early on during the two-hour journey, the discussion veered round to Gujarat. There was a long spell of silence as Atalji went into a contemplative mood, which was broken by (Jaswant) Singh asking him, ‘What do you think Atalji?’ Atalji replied, ‘*Kam se kam isteepe ka offer to karte.*’ (Modi should have at least offered to resign). I then said, “If Modi's quitting is going to improve the situation in Gujarat, I am willing to tell him to offer his resignation. I am not sure whether the party's national council or executive would accept the offer.”

As soon as we arrived in Goa, I called Modi and said that he should offer to resign. He readily agreed. When the deliberations of the national executive began, many members spoke and put across their points of view. After listening to all of them, Modi spoke and recounted in great detail the